

Soundcestral Remembrance: Fugitive Memory, Congo Square, and the Resistance Against Historical Erasure



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Tylar Campbell
tylar_campbell@sfu.ca

School of Interactive Arts & Technology, Simon Fraser University, Canada

Abstract

This presentation focuses on urgent memory work at Congo Square, a landmark of Black cultural history in New Orleans that embodies both resistance and erasure. I advance the framework of Soundcestral Remembrance—the practice of sustaining cultural memory and ancestral presence through sound, rhythm, and gathering. Drawing on multimodal narrative anthropology and ongoing fieldwork, this case study interrogates how Congo Square operates simultaneously as a site of remembrance and a battleground against systemic erasure.

The November 2025 AAA conference coincides with the anniversary of November 23, 1997, when the Congo Square plaque was installed following decades of advocacy by the Congo Square Preservation Society. Today, preservation faces renewed threats amid political efforts to dismantle Black historical recognition and weaken national memory infrastructures. Through attention to sound, embodied memory, and community space-making, this project demonstrates how African diasporic memory traditions endure despite erasure, foregrounding rhythm as a vehicle of cultural continuity, resistance, and survival. By situating Congo Square within current attacks on Black history in the United States, this work highlights anthropology's critical role in documenting, safeguarding, and amplifying cultural memory in what Katherine McKittrick calls "terrains of struggle"—engaging with preservation, erasure, and resistance as live, urgent issues rather than historical inevitabilities.

Objectives

- Multimodal Narrative Anthropology — Preserve heritage with drones, photogrammetry, immersive technologies, and a podcast
- Fugitivity as Lens: Examine how Black communities forge "rival geographies" and use technology as fugitive practice.
- Research-Creation Methodology: Blend scholarly analysis with artistic production through iterative cycles of creation, reflection, and refinement.
- TraversingSpaces.com — Develop an interactive, geolocated website mapping fugitive narratives across North America.

Conclusion

- Fugitive Memories Endure: This research demonstrates that African diasporic memory persists through embodied practice, sound, and community gathering—even when official recognition is delayed, contested, or denied. Congo Square exemplifies how Soundcestral Remembrance operates as both cultural continuity and resistance.
- Multimodal Anthropology as Preservation Praxis: Combining spatial mapping, drone documentation, immersive video, and embodied fieldwork creates layered archives that honor how Black communities sustain memory beyond institutional frameworks. This methodological approach reveals what traditional archival methods miss.
- The Stakes of Now: Amid escalating threats to Black historical spaces, anthropologists must engage preservation as urgent intervention, not retrospective documentation. Congo Square's continued practice amplifying community wellness through preserving sound as cultural memory is a testament to this kind of work.
- Toward Transnational Fugitive Geographies: This case study advances a broader framework for understanding how Black settlements across borders maintain memory through rhythm, space, and gathering—tracing fugitive histories that refuse erasure and insist on being remembered.

Late Breaking: This research coincides with the 28th anniversary of Congo Square's November 23, 1997 plaque installation—a recognition achieved only after decades of community advocacy, revealing the contested politics of Black historical memory.

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Fig.1 Aerial photo of N. Rampart St. and Orleans St.



Fig.2 Congo Square plaque, National Register 1993 / installed 1997

Discussion

- Soundcestral Remembrance as Living Archive: Sound, rhythm, and gathering constitute memory work beyond official recognition—drumming ceremonies reveal remembrance as active practice, not static commemoration.
- Recognition Gaps & Power: Congo Square's belated 1997 plaque installation—achieved only through decades of community advocacy—reveals who controls historical narrative and which Black spaces gain legitimacy. Twenty-eight years later, the struggle continues.
- Multimodal Methods as Counter-Archive: Drone footage, 360-video, and sensory fieldwork capture what bronze reliefs cannot—the atmospheric, sonic, and affective dimensions absent from traditional heritage designation.
- Embodied Knowledge: Traversing spaces reveals how communities sanctify sites through continued gathering, honoring local practice as legitimate historical evidence alongside archival data.
- Urgent Intervention: Current attacks on Black historical recognition transform preservation from retrospective work into immediate resistance—Congo Square exemplifies McKittrick's "terrains of struggle" where memory work is contested in real time.
- Transnational Connections: This case extends to broader patterns of Black fugitive settlement and memory-making across the borders traced in the larger dissertation project.



Fig.3 Spirit of Congo Square bronze relief with dancers and drummers



Fig.5 Spirit of Congo Square detail II.



• Fig.4 Drums and Drones fieldwork aerial still, rite of passage ceremony (scan qr code to see 360 video)



Fig.6 Drums and Drones fieldwork on Fugitive Sound & cultural preservation of drumming.

Methodology

Dataset Creation

National Register Mapping & Analysis: Collection and spatial mapping of National Registered Historic Places and Landmarks that designate significance to African American Heritage sites, including settlements, burial grounds, and cultural gathering spaces. This dataset reveals patterns in institutional recognition and exposes gaps between officially registered sites and community sustained memory spaces.

Drone & 360 Camera Documentation

Drone: Used to fly over and record video footage alongside aerial photography of Congo Square, adding a three-dimensional layer of perspective to complement the site's bronze relief and ground-level experience.

360 Camera: Used to capture immersive video footage of contemporary dance and rites of passage ceremonies transpiring in the space, documenting how Soundcestral Remembrance practices continue today.

Case Study

In this study, Congo Square, a sacred yet fugitive space is utilized for gathering, drumming, and dance (figure 3.) A historical depiction alongside contemporary visual can be seen in figures 3, 4, 5 & 6.

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